

Cultural Dialogue in Asia

Cultural Diversity and Asia Cooperation

“Cultural Dialogue between Iran and the Subcontinent: Spirituality and Sufism”

I

Being a Buddhist by birth and also by faith, it is really interesting, thought – provoking and soul – searching to go deep in to aspects of spirituality Sufism, for the deeper side of Buddhism emphasizes spirituality in one’s ultimate salvation.

There is no single, widely agreed definition of spirituality. Surveys of the definition of the term, as used in scholarly research, show a broad range of definitions ranging from uni-dimensional definitions such as a personal belief in a [supernatural](#) realm to broader concepts such as a quest for an ultimate/sacred meaning, transcending the base/material aspects of life, and/or a sense of awe/wonderment and reverence toward the universe

According to Kees Waaijman, the traditional meaning of spirituality is a process of re-formation which "aims to recover the original shape of man, the image of God. To accomplish this, the re-formation is oriented at a mold, which represents the original shape: in [Judaism](#) the [Torah](#), in [Christianity](#) there is [Christ](#), for [Buddhism](#), [Buddha](#), and in [Islam](#), [Muhammad](#)." In modern times the emphasis is on subjective experience and the "deepest values and meanings by which people live," incorporating [personal growth or transformation](#), usually in a context separate from organized religious institutions. Houtman and Aupers suggest that modern spirituality is a blend of humanistic psychology, mystical and esoteric traditions and eastern religions.

Words translatable as 'spirituality' first began to arise in the 5th century and only entered common use toward the end of the Middle Ages. In a Biblical context the term means being animated by God, to be driven by the [Holy Spirit](#), as opposed to a life which rejects this influence.

In the 11th century this meaning changed. Spirituality began to denote the mental aspect of life, as opposed to the material and sensual aspects of life, "the ecclesiastical sphere of light against the dark world of matter".

In the 13th century "spirituality" acquired a social and psychological meaning. Socially it denoted the territory of the clergy: "The ecclesiastical against the temporary possessions, the ecclesiastical against the secular authority, the clerical class against the secular class"

Psychologically, it denoted the realm of the inner life: "The purity of motives, affections, intentions, inner dispositions, the psychology of the spiritual life, the analysis of the feelings".

The Pillars of Islam (*arkan al-Islam*; also *arkan ad-din*, "pillars of religion") are five basic acts in Islam, considered obligatory for all believers. The [Quran](#) presents them as a framework for worship and a sign of commitment to the faith. They are (1) the [shahadah](#) (creed), (2) daily prayers ([salat](#)), (3) almsgiving ([zakah](#)), (4) fasting during [Ramadan](#) and (5) the pilgrimage to Mecca ([hajj](#)) at least once in a lifetime. The [Shia](#) and [Sunni](#) sects both agree on the essential details for the performance of these acts.

The best known form of Islamic mystic spirituality is the [Sufi](#) tradition (famous through [Rumi](#) and [Hafiz](#)) in which a spiritual master or [pir](#) transmits spiritual discipline to students.

Sufism or *taṣawwuf* is defined by its adherents as the inner, [mystical](#) dimension of [Islam](#). A practitioner of this tradition is generally known as a *ṣūfī*. Sufis believe they are practicing [ihsan](#) (perfection of worship) as revealed by [Gabriel](#) to [Muhammad](#),

Worship and serve [Allah](#) as you are seeing Him and while you see Him not yet truly He sees you.

Sufis consider themselves as the original true proponents of this pure original form of Islam. They are strong adherents to the principal of tolerance, peace and against any form of violence. The Sufi have suffered severe persecution by more rigid and fundamentalist groups such as the [Wahhabi](#) and [Salafi movement](#). In 1843 the [Senussi](#) Sufi were forced to flee Mecca and Medina and head to Sudan and Libya.

Classical Sufi scholars have defined Sufism as "a science whose objective is the reparation of the heart and turning it away from all else but God". Alternatively, in the words of the [Dargawi](#) Sufi teacher [Ahmad ibn Ajiba](#), "a science through which one can know how to travel into the [presence of the Divine](#), purify one's inner self from filth, and beautify it with a variety of praiseworthy traits".

II

Sufism is the esotery school of Islam. founded on the pursuit of spiritual truth as a definite goal to attain the truth of understanding reality as it truly is, as knowledge. When we speak of understanding or cognition we refer to that perfect self-understanding that leads to the understanding of the Divine. This very logical principle is based on a typically succinct saying of Prophet Mohammed: "Whoever knows oneself, knows one's Lord." The origins of Sufism can be traced to the heart of Islam in the time of the Prophet, whose teachings attracted a group of scholars who came to be called "ahle suffe" the People of Suffe, from their practice of sitting at the platform of the mosque of

the Prophet in Medina. There they engaged in discussions concerning the reality of Being, and in search of the inner path they devoted themselves to spiritual purification and mediation.

The *ahle suffice* believed that it was the unique human right and privilege to be able to find the way towards understanding the reality of the Divine. As the cognitive tools of ordinary mental logic are limited in their ability to comprehend such a great and all-embracing subject, disputation and all discussions based on language alone cannot open any door to understanding such reality. Instead, such a path of understanding necessitates spiritual striving, the understanding and the knowledge of the heart, in its quest to realize the existence of the Divine. Such an approach separates Sufis from philosophers, and indeed from any other group of scholars whose knowledge is founded upon traditions, words, assumptions, and the imagination instead of the actual and direct understanding of all that exists. Thus the path of Sufis, of cognizant Moslems, was separate from that of the traditional understanding. They became the people of the *tarigh*, or the way; their particular goal was to understand and introduce the esoteric aspect of Islam, as opposed to the exoteric public elements of this universal religion.

The principles of Sufism are all based upon the rules and teachings of the Koran and the instructions of the Prophet. To a Sufi there is no gulf of separation between all of Being, the Creator, and His creations. If man were free from the limitations of matter, then he would surely witness this immense and eternal unity of Being. But there is a chance for making to ascend to such a level of understanding, a pathway that can be followed through purification and meditation to the realization of its achievement. When one's heart is purified, the manifestations of the Divine is reflected in the mirror of the heart. Only then may man ascend from the level of his animal nature to the level of the true human being.

Since all the principles that underlie the instructions of Sufis are based on the Koran, it is impossible to relate Sufism to any religion outside of Islam. Yet the search for true understanding and abstract knowledge of reality is a universal quest. As long as humanity endures, so too will the search for such understanding continues. History shows us that every nation and religion has its own way of expressing the universal spiritual quest.

It is because of the inner truth to Sufism, a belief system and discipline free from the confines of time and place, that people from diverse cultural backgrounds and all walks of life, who are, yet, seeking a common pathway to an eternal and transcendent truth, can call themselves Sufis. It is easy to think of Sufism as an abstract doctrine. It is

easy to think of Sufism as an open gateway that leads to the garden of truth, as a path of love which requires no endeavor. It is all too easy if we tend to forget that the inner strength of Sufism has been established through and from the personal qualifications, devotion and intellectual ability of those who have defined the quest of truth, that lies at the heart of Sufism.

Sufism has been referred to as a path, a journey, a journey of the heart. Such a journey has a beginning; a point of departure that leads towards a destination. A Sufi takes an inner journey to attain the knowledge of Self, a knowledge that leads towards the understanding the Divine. A journey towards understanding such truth will necessarily involve steps, one has to pass through stations of learning, awareness and understanding. One must learn the rules, disciplines and practices. One does not become a Sufi without honoring the rules of the Path. Being attracted to the teachings of Sufism does not necessarily make one a Sufi.

In Sufism, the traveler departs from the station of limited knowledge and understanding and takes the journey towards the destination of greater understanding, understanding the Divine. The foundation of such a journey is based on the individual's recognition of his or her own limited knowledge and a desire to expand such knowledge and ultimately surpass its limitation. In passing the successive stages of the journey, the traveler will learn the meaning of Divinity, will finally arrive at the stages of heart, all knowledgeable, tranquil and aware to witness Divine illumination.

In the journey of the heart the Sufi, the traveler, becomes enraptured by the magnificent existence of the Divine, the Divine becomes the eternal Beloved and the journey becomes the journey of the lovers towards the Beloved where finally the Sufi declares:

“God is Love, Prophet is Love, Religion is Love

From the smallest grain of sand to the highest heavens

All are enraptured by love.”

Throughout the world of Sufism, love has become the eternal theme, Sufis have gracefully glorified this theme in their poetry, in their principles, in their songs and practices, to the point that the Sufi proclaims:

“Let love exist

No fear if I exist or not

Let this iron change into gold

Rising from this fire of love”

(Moulana Shah Maghsound, 20th Century Persian Sufi)

III

Over the centuries, gradually two systems of Sufism developed: practical Sufism and philosophical Sufism.

Sufism is established on the essential laws of Being, and the laws of Being are timeless, free from dimensions of time and place and the limitations of human qualities. Individuals do have the ability to understand the laws of Being, yet they cannot change the laws. The same principle applies in Sufism. As a result, the essential principles of Sufism have remained free from the dimensions of time or place, gender or race, cultures or ceremonies and all human qualities.

When a traveler of the journey of the heart, a Sufi, passes the stages of Being and arrives at the ocean of infinity, when passes from the world of multiplicity to discover essential unity, when passes from the world of multiplicity to discover essential unity, when the walls of nature fall, and the manifestation of the Divine reflects into the heart of the seeker where he discovers the bounty of the existence after complete annihilation, capable of witnessing Divine illumination, he has entered the realm of Practical Sufism. Such essential law does not change as cultures or times change.

When Practical Sufism has entered different cultures and times, sometimes its surface might have taken the colors of cultures and times, but its essence has remained secure and unchanged in the chests of its owners. This spiritual journey is not a matter of chance, of following intuition or trusting empty verbal formula. Rather, it is an expedition carried out in accordance with definite rules. Practical Sufism did not deviate and change from its original mission.

Parallel to this school, another line of Sufism has developed since the 12th-13th century. When a few Sufi teachers began to explain the laws and mysteries of creation and governing principles of Sufism within the confines of the philosophical language, so people could better understand, they created, knowingly or not, Philosophical Sufism; a descriptive Sufism based more on explanations, philosophy and history.

The expansion and development of Philosophical Sufism was faster, since it was easier to understand.

This belief system, founded on the principles of Islam, gradually became an interesting discovery for a few western researchers. These researchers, or Orientalists, focusing on this middle eastern stoicism, have translated or written commentaries on the works of Sufis, yet not all those researchers were familiar with those cultures, Sufism and the dominating languages including the language of Sufism itself. Many of these researchers have taken Philosophical Sufism as Practical Sufism and introduced it to their readers.

Practical Sufism is based on practice while philosophical Sufism focuses on the verbal explanation of the practice, history of principles of Sufism. Such explanation, even though useful, yet without doubt, can always be conditional. It is conditioned upon the level of the writer's understanding of Sufism and on his or her level of prejudice, personal qualifications, likes and dislikes. Philosophical Sufism can also be bound to the limitation of language and words used to describe a practice. We all know how the meaning behind the words varies from one culture to another.

Even though these two systems of Sufism are different from each other, it is not always easy for an observer to distinguish between the two, especially since sometimes ceremonies and traditions may become more interesting, therefore easily replacing the quest for the truth which lies in the heart of Sufism.

IV

Mysticism is that aspect of Islamic belief and practice in which Muslims seek to find the truth of divine love and knowledge through direct personal experience of God. It consists the nature of man and God and to facilitate the experience of the presence of divine love and wisdom in the world.

Islamic mysticism is called tasawwuf (literally, "to dress in wool") in Arabic, but it has been called Sufism in Western languages since the early 19th century. An abstract

word, Sufism derives from the Arabic term for a mystic, Sufi, which is in turn derived from Suf. “wool,” plausibly a reference to the woolen garment of early Islamic ascetics. The Sufis are also generally known as “the poor” Fuqara, plural of the Arabic fakir, in Persian dervish, whence the English words fakir and dervish.

Though the roots of Islamic mysticism formerly were supposed to have stemmed from various non-Islamic sources in ancient Europe and even India, it now seems established that the movement grew out of early Islamic asceticism that developed as a counterweight to the increasing worldliness of the expanding Muslim community, only later were foreign elements that were compatible with mystical theology and practices adopted and made to conform to Islam.

By educating the masses and deepening the spiritual concerns of the Muslims, Sufism has played an important role in the formation of Muslim society. Opposed to the dry casuistry of the lawyer-divines, the mystics nevertheless scrupulously observed the commands of the divine law. The Sufis have been further responsible for a large-scale missionary activity all over the world, which still continues. Sufis have elaborated the image of the prophet Muhammad-the founder of Islam-and have thus largely influenced Muslim piety by their Muhammad-mysticism. Without the Sufi vocabulary, Persian and other literatures related to it, such as Turkish Urdu, Sindhi, Pashto, and Panjabi, would lack their special charms. Through the poetry of these literatures mystical ideas spread widely among the Muslims. In some countries Sufi leaders were also active politically.

The 13th century, though politically overshadowed by the invasion of the Mongals into the Eastern lands of Islam and the end of the Abbasid caliphate was also the golden age of Sufism the Spanish, born Ibn al Arabi created a comprehensive theosophical system (concerning the relation of God and the world) that was to become the cornerstone for a theory of “Unity of Being” According to this theory all existence is one, a manifestation of the underlying divine reality. His Egyptian contemporary Ibn Al-Farid wrote the finest mystical poems in Arabic. Two other important mystics, who died C AD 1220, were a Persian poet, Firdos-Din Attar, one of the most fertile writers on mystical topics, and Central Asian master. Najmuddin Kubra, who presented elaborate discussions of the psychological experiences through which the mystic adept has to pass.

The greatest mystical poet in the Persian language, Jalal ad-Din ar-Rumi (1207-73), was moved by mystical love to compose his lyrical poetry that he attributed to his mystical beloved. Shams ad-Din of Tabriz, as a symbol of their union. Rumi’s didactic poem *Masnawi* in about 26,000 couplets-a work that is for the Persian reading mystics second in importance only to the Quran – is an Encyclopedia of mystical thought in

which everyone can find his own religious ideas. Rumi inspired the organization of the whirling dervishes – who sought ecstasy through an elaborate dancing ritual, accompanied by superb music. His younger contemporary Yunus Emir inaugurated Turkish mystical poetry with his charming verses that were transmitted by the Bektashiya (Bektasi) order of dervishes and are still admired in modern Turkey. In Egypt, among many other mystical trends, an order – known as Shadhiliyah – was founded by Ishaq – Shadhili (died 1258): its main literary representative Ibn ‘Ata Allah of Alexandria, wrote sober aphorisms (hikam).

At that time, the basic ideals of Sufism permeated the whole world of Islam and at its borders as for example in India, Sufis largely contributed to shaping Islamic society. Later some of the Sufis in India were brought closer to Hindu mysticism by an overemphasis on the idea of divine unity which became almost monism- religious philosophic perspective according to which there is only one basic reality, and the distinction between God and the word (and man) tends to disappear. The syncretistic attempts of the Mughal emperor Akbar (died 1605) to combine different forms of belief and practice, and the religious discussions of the crown prince Dara Shukoh (executed for heresy, 1659) were objectionable to the orthodox. Typically, the countermovement was again undertaken by a mystical order, the Naqshbandiyah, a Central Asian fraternity founded in the 14th century. Contrary to the monistic trends of the school of wahdat al-wujud (“existential unity of being”), the later Naqshbandiyah defended the wahdat ash-shuhud (“unity of vision”) a subjective experience of unity, occurring only in the mind of the believer, and not as an objective experience. Ahmad Sirhindi (died 1624) was the major protagonist of this movement in India. His claims of sanctity were surprisingly daring : he considered himself the divinely invested master of the universe. His refusal to concede the possibility of union between man and God (characterized as *‘servant and Lord*) and his sober law-bound attitude gained him and his followers many disciples, even at the Mughal court and as far away as Turkey. In the 18th century, Shah Wali Allah of Delhi was connected with an attempt to reach a compromise between the two inimical schools of mysticism; he was also politically active and translated the Quran into Persian, the official language of Mughal India. Other Indian mystics of the 18th century, such as Mir Dard, played a decisive role in forming the newly developing Urdu poetry. In the Arabic parts of the Islamic world, only a few interesting mystical authors are found after 1500. They include Ishaq-Sha’rani in Egypt (died 1565) and the prolific writer ‘Abd al-Ghani an-Nabusi in Syria (died 1731). Turkey produced some fine mystical poets in the 17th and 18th centuries. The influence of the mystical orders did not recede ; rather new orders came into existence, and most literature was still tinged with mystical ideas and expressions. Political and

social reformers in the Islamic countries have often objected to Sufism because they have generally considered it as backward, hampering the free development of society. Thus, the orders and dervish lodges in Turkey were closed by Kemal Ataturk in 1925. Yet, their political influence is still palpable though under the surface. Such modern Islamic thinkers as the Indian philosopher Muhammad Iqbal have attacked traditional monist mysticism and have gone back to the classical ideals of divine love as expressed by Rumi and his contemporaries. The activities of modern Muslim mystics in the cities are mostly restricted to spiritual education.

The mystics drew their vocabulary largely from the Quran, which for Muslims contains all divine wisdom and has to be interpreted with ever-increasing insight. In the Quran, mystics found the threat of the Last Judgment, but they also found the statement that God “loves them and they love him,” which became the basis for love-mysticism. Strict obedience to the religious law and imitation of the Prophet were basic for the mystics. By rigid introspection and mental struggles the mystic tried to purify his baser self from even the smallest signs of selfishness, thus attaining *ikhlas*, absolute purity of intention and act. Tawakkul (trust in God) was sometimes practiced to such an extent that every thought of tomorrow was considered irreligious. “Little sleep, little talk, little food” were fundamental; fasting became one of the most important preparations for the spiritual life.

The central concern of the Sufis, as of every Muslim, was *tawhid*, the witness that “There is no deity but God.” This truth had to be realized in the existence of each individual and so the expressions differ, early Sufism postulated the approach to God through love and voluntary suffering until a unity of will was reached; Junayd spoke of “recognizing God as He was before creation”; God is seen as the One and only actor; He alone “has the right to say ‘I’.” Later *tawhid* came to mean the knowledge that there is nothing existent but God, or the ability to see God and creation as two aspects of one reality, reflecting each other and depending upon each other (*wahdat al-wujud*). The mystics realized that beyond the knowledge of outward sciences intuitive knowledge was required in order to receive that illumination to which reason has no access. *Dhawq*, direct “tasting” of experience, was essential for them. But the inspirations and “unveilings” that God grants such mystics by special grace must never contradict the Quran and tradition and are valid only for the person concerned. Even the *Malamatis*, who attracted public contempt upon themselves by outwardly acting against the law, in private life strictly followed the divine commands. Mystics who expressed in their poetry their disinterest in, and even contempt of, the traditional formal religions never forgot that Islam is the highest manifestation of divine wisdom.

The divine truth was at times revealed to the mystic in visions, auditions, and dreams, in colors and sounds, but to convey these non rational and ineffable experiences to others the mystic had to rely upon such terminology of worldly experience as that of love and intoxication –often objectionable from the orthodox viewpoint. The symbolism of wine, cup and cupbearer, first expressed by Abu Yazid al-Bistami in the 9th century, became popular everywhere, whether in the verses of the Arab Ibn al-Farid, or the Persian Iraqi, or the Turk Yunus Emre, and their followers. The hope for the union of the soul with the divine had to be expressed through images of human yearning and love. The love for lovely boys in which the divine beauty manifests itself – according to the alleged Hadith “I saw my Lord in the shape of a youth with a cap awry”-was commonplace in Persian poetry. Union was described as the submersion of the drop in the ocean, the state of the iron in the fire, the vision of penetrating light, or the burning of the moth in the candle (first used by Hallaj) Worldly phenomena in the candle (first used by Hallaj). Worldly phenomena were seen as black tresses veiling the radiant beauty of the divine countenance. The mystery of unity and diversity was symbolized, for example, under the image of mirrors that reflect the different aspects of the divine, or as prisms coloring the pure light. Every aspect of nature was seen in relation to God. The symbol of the soul bird – in which the human soul is likened to a flying bird – known everywhere, was the entre of ‘Attar’s Manteq otteyr (“the Birds’ Conversation”). The predilection of the mystical poets for the symbolism of the nightingale and rose (the red rose _God’s perfect beauty; nightingale = soul; first used by Baqli [died 1203]) stems from the soul bird symbolism. For spiritual education, symbols taken from medicine (healing of the sick soul) and alchemy (changing of base matter into gold) were also used. Many descriptions that were originally applied to God as the goal of love were, in later times, used also for the Prophet, who is said to be like the “dawn between the darkness of the material world and the sun of Reality.”

Allusions to the Quran were frequent, especially so to verses that seem to imply divine immense (God’s presence in the world), such as “Whithersoever ye turn, there is the Face of God” (surah 2:109), or that God is “Closer than your neck-vein” (surah 50:8) Surah 7:172 –i.e. God’s address to the uncreated children of Adam (“Am I not your Lord” [alastu birabbikum]) – came to denote the pre-eternal love relation between God and man. As for the prophets before Muhammad, the vision of Moses was considered still imperfect, for the mystic wants the actual vision of God, not His manifestation through a burning bush. Abrahm, for whom fire turned into a rose garden. resembles the mystic in the afflictions; Joseph, in his perfect beauty, the mystic in his afflictions; Joseph, in his perfect beauty , the mystical beloved after whom the mystic are numerous; such as “Heaven and earth do not contain me, but the heart of my faithful servant

contains Me” and the possibility of a relation between man and God is also explained by the traditional idea: “He (God) created Adam in His image.”

The underlying reality of Sufism is its spirituality which could bind individuals, cultures, nations and ultimately the entire mankind. Ignoring differences of religious sects and various doctrines, Sufism can embrace nations of the Sub continent in a spirit of mutual understanding and respect.

V

Sufism has helped to shape large parts of Muslim society. The orthodox disagree with such aspects of Sufism as saint worship, visiting of tombs, musical performances, miracle mongering, degeneration into jugglery, and the adaptation of pre-Islamic and un-Islamic customs: and the reformers object to the influences of the monistic interpretation of Islam upon moral life and human activities. The importance given to the figure of the master is accused of yielding negative results; the shaykh as the almost infallible leader of his disciples and admirers could gain dangerous authority and political influence, for the illiterate villagers in backward areas used to rely completely upon the “saint” Yet, other masters have raised their voices against social inequality and have tried, even at the cost of their lives, to change social and political conditions for the better and to spiritually revive the masses. The missionary activities of the Sufis have enlarged the fold of the faithful. The importance of Sufism for spiritual education, and inculcation in the faithful of the virtues of trust in God, piety, faith in God’s love, and veneration of the Prophet, cannot be overrated. The dhikr formulas still preserve their consoling and quieting power even for the illiterate. Mysticism permeates Persian literature and other literatures influenced by it. Such poetry has always been a source of happiness for millions, although some modernists have disdained its “narcotic” influence on Muslim thinking.

Industrialization and modern life have led to a constant decrease in the influence of Sufi orders in many countries. The spiritual heritage is preserved by individuals who sometimes try to show that mystical experience conforms to modern science. Today in the West, Sufism is popularized, but the genuinely and authentically devout are aware that it requires strict discipline, and that its goal can be reached – if at all – as they say, only by throwing oneself into the consuming fire of divine love.

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